

“Foundations of Trust”

A Professionalism Case Study Script

Situation: A contractor offers a site engineer extra money to approve substandard materials so the project can meet its deadline.

Cast (5 Members)

#	Role	Description
1	Engr. Ronn Caniya	Site/Project Engineer — the one being tempted
2	Mr. Dherick Discaya	Contractor — under pressure to finish on time
3	Engr. Marc Christer Saballo	Project Manager — Ronn's supervisor
4	Ms. Rodesa Padua	QA/QC Inspector — Ronn's colleague
5	Mr. Mikhale Dalao	Client Representative — will receive the finished structure

Outline

1. Scene 1 – The Offer: Discaya privately pressures Caniya and offers a cash incentive to approve a concrete pour that failed its curing-strength test.

2. Scene 2 – The Gut-Check: Caniya brings the test cylinders to Padua, who confirms the concrete is under-strength. Caniya weighs the deadline against the building's foundation safety.

3. Scene 3 – The Refusal & Report: Caniya declines the money and files a nonconformance report with Saballo instead of quietly signing off.

4. Scene 4 – Escalation & Resolution: Saballo briefs Dalao; the team agrees to break out and repour the affected section rather than cover it up.

5. Scene 5 – Debrief: The five characters name the pillar of professionalism their own actions represented.

Full Script

Scene 1 – The Offer

(A site trailer, blueprints spread across the table. DISCAYA leans in.)

DISCAYA: Goodmorning, Engr. Ronn, the 28-days break test came in low on that foundation pour — I know. But we're two weeks from turnover. Sign the strength report as passing, and there's 100% guaranteed fifty thousand for you, just for you, no questions asked and we both know the client won't check.

CANIYA: (setting down the test report) Dherick, "low" isn't a rounding error here — that's the concrete holding up the whole structure above it. I can't put my signature on a number that isn't real.

DISCAYA: Nobody's going to core-test a finished foundation, your an engineer, right? Come on, sign this strength report. This conversation stays between us. Nobody gonna know this, its the two of us.

[PILLAR IN TENSION: Integrity vs. financial temptation and schedule pressure]

Scene 2 – The Gut-Check

(QA trailer. CANIYA lays the cylinder-break data in front of PADUA.)

PADUA: Ronn, these numbers are almost 15% below the specified compressive strength. That's not within any acceptable tolerance — it's a structural risk.

CANIYA: I know. And Discaya just offered me money to sign it off as passing anyway.

PADUA: Then the numbers already answered the question for you. I'll log the failed cylinders formally so there's no ambiguity in the record.

[PILLAR DEMONSTRATED — Competence: Caniya and Padua rely on verified test data, not pressure or convenience, to make the call.]

Scene 3 – The Refusal & Report

(Back in the trailer. CANIYA slides the unsigned report across to DISCAYA.)

CANIYA: Dherick, I'm not signing this, and I'm not taking the money. I'm submitting a nonconformance report to Saballo today.

DISCAYA: What? Are you kidding me? Where running out of time you know, you're going to reopen a poured foundation over a lab number?

CANIYA: That “lab number” is the only thing standing between a safe building and a future collapse. I'd rather be the engineer who caused a delay than the one who signed off on a disaster.

[PILLAR DEMONSTRATED — Integrity: Caniya refuses personal gain that would put public safety and his professional license at risk.]

Scene 4 – Escalation & Resolution

(Project office. CANIYA presents the report to SABALLO. DALAO joins by video call.)

SABALLO: Ronn, I appreciate you flagging this directly instead of letting it pass. What's the remedy, and what's the cost to the schedule?

CANIYA: We break out the affected section and repour — roughly eight working days, fully documented with Padua's test data.

DALAO: (on screen) Eight days is a manageable adjustment. What wouldn't be manageable is occupying a building on a foundation we knew had failed. Thank you for being upfront — proceed with the repour.

SABALLO: Dherick, we'll revise the timeline together and communicate the reason plainly to the client. No shortcuts on this project.

[PILLAR DEMONSTRATED — Accountability: Caniya owns the problem by reporting it rather than hiding it; Saballo and Dalao accept the consequences instead of pressuring a cover-up.]

[PILLAR DEMONSTRATED — Respect: Every party treats the client's trust and the future occupants' safety as non-negotiable.]

Scene 5 – Debrief (Narrated or spoken directly to the audience)

CANIYA: I stayed committed to my duty as an engineer, even when a shortcut was offered on a silver platter.

PADUA: I applied my competence honestly — the test data spoke, not convenience.

SABALLO: I held accountability for my project's decisions instead of looking the other way.

DALAO: I extended respect to the people who will one day work inside that building.

DISCAYA: (reflective) And I learned that cutting corners doesn't save a deadline — it only moves the real cost further down the road.

Notes for Performance

- Scene 1 should feel like a genuine, low-key temptation — the offer is framed as “harmless” and private, which is what makes the refusal meaningful.
- Consider bringing a prop (a folder labeled “28-Day Strength Test”) for Scene 2 to visually anchor the technical stakes.
- Scene 5 can be delivered as direct address to the audience, or woven back into a closing conversation if your instructor prefers realism over narration.
- Running time: roughly 4–6 minutes at a natural pace.

Moral Dilemmas Commonly Encountered by Professionals

Professionals across every field tend to run into the same handful of dilemma types — the details change (a nurse vs. an auditor vs. an engineer), but the underlying tension repeats. Below are the most common types, each with the specific ethical issue at its core.

1. Integrity vs. Personal or Organizational Gain

Example: *A contractor offers an engineer money to approve substandard materials and meet a deadline (this case study's scenario).*

Key issue: Integrity — whether the professional's judgment can be bought, and whether short-term gain is allowed to override truthful reporting.

2. Loyalty to Employer vs. Duty to the Public (Whistleblowing)

Example: *An employee discovers their company is dumping waste illegally or covering up a safety defect.*

Key issue: Accountability vs. loyalty — does obligation to the organization outweigh obligation to public safety or the law?

3. Confidentiality vs. Disclosure

Example: *A doctor, lawyer, or IT professional learns something that could harm a third party if kept secret (a patient's contagious illness, a data breach affecting users).*

Key issue: Confidentiality vs. duty to warn — professional secrecy has limits when others are put at risk.

4. Competence Boundaries

Example: *A professional is asked to take on work outside their expertise (an engineer signing off on a discipline they're not licensed in, a junior developer deploying code they don't fully understand) because no one else is available.*

Key issue: Competence and honesty about limitations — claiming or accepting authority you don't actually have.

5. Conflict of Interest

Example: *An auditor is asked to review the finances of a company owned by a close relative; a procurement officer's brother-in-law owns the winning supplier.*

Key issue: Objectivity and impartiality — whether personal relationships are quietly shaping a supposedly neutral decision.

6. Fairness and Resource Allocation

Example: *A manager must decide which of two equally deserving employees gets a limited promotion or bonus; a hospital must triage patients with scarce ICU beds.*

Key issue: Fairness/justice — applying consistent, defensible criteria rather than favoritism or convenience.

7. Compliance vs. Pressure to Cut Corners

Example: *A quality inspector is pushed by management to pass a batch that technically fails inspection because a client shipment is already late.*

Key issue: Professional responsibility vs. institutional pressure — whether standards bend under time or cost pressure.

8. Personal Values vs. Professional Obligation

Example: *A lawyer personally disagrees with a client's position but is professionally obligated to represent them; a pharmacist has a moral objection to filling a legal prescription.*

Key issue: Role morality — where the line sits between personal conscience and the duties that come with the role.

The common thread: almost every one of these dilemmas comes down to the same underlying question — does the professional protect their integrity, competence, and the public's trust, or do they yield to pressure (financial, social, institutional, or personal)? That's exactly the tension this script's bribery scenario dramatizes: it's really a stand-in for dilemma type 1, with type 7 (schedule pressure) layered on top.